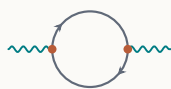


NOTES ON

Quantum Field Theory



These notes are an unoriginal collection drawn from standard textbooks and lecture notes that I have gone over while trying to learn quantum field theory.

Swastik Majumder

Center for Cosmology and AstroParticle Physics
Department of Physics, The Ohio State University

September 5, 2026



Contents

1	Classical field theory	2
1.1	Units, notation, and dimensional analysis	2
1.1.1	Natural units	2
1.1.2	Mass dimension	2
1.2	Lorentz transformations and index notation	3
1.2.1	Events, intervals, and the metric	3
1.2.2	Contravariant and covariant objects	4
1.2.3	Derivatives and index placement	4
1.2.4	Lorentz-invariant contractions	5
1.3	Relativistic single-particle quantum mechanics and its limitations	5
1.4	Classical fields and the action principle	6
1.4.1	From coordinates to fields	6
1.4.2	Deriving the field Euler–Lagrange equations	6
1.4.3	Higher-derivative Lagrangians	7
1.5	Examples of Euler–Lagrange equations	8
1.5.1	A real scalar field	8
1.5.2	A complex scalar field	8
1.5.3	The electromagnetic field	9
1.6	Continuous symmetries and Noether’s theorem	9
1.6.1	Weak and strong forms	10
1.6.2	Internal symmetries	10
1.6.3	Spacetime translations and the energy momentum tensor	11

Conventions at a glance

Throughout, Greek indices $\mu, \nu, \dots$ run over spacetime components $0, 1, 2, 3$. The Latin indices $i, j, \dots$ run over spatial components $1, 2, 3$, and repeated upper–lower index pairs are summed. We use

$$\hbar = c = 1, \quad \eta_{\mu\nu} = \text{diag}(1, -1, -1, -1), \quad x^\mu = (t, \mathbf{x}).$$

The metric choice is sometimes called the *mostly-minus* convention.

1 Classical field theory

This chapter introduces the notation and basic principles used throughout quantum field theory. We begin with natural units, dimensional analysis, and the Lorentz transformation properties of spacetime quantities. The limitations of relativistic single-particle quantum mechanics are then discussed, motivating the transition to quantum fields. Finally, we review classical field theory, the action principle, the derivation of field equations of motion and Noether's theorem.

1.1 Units, notation, and dimensional analysis

1.1.1 Natural units

Relativistic quantum theory contains two universal conversion constants: c , and $\hbar$. Setting

$$c = \hbar = 1, \quad (1.1.1)$$

This convention allows time, length, mass, momentum, and energy to be expressed in terms of a single base unit, with the conversion factors suppressed. Thus

$$[E] = [p] = [m], \quad [t] = [x] = [E]^{-1}. \quad (1.1.2)$$

For restoring ordinary units, two useful identities are

$$\hbar c \simeq 0.19732698 \text{ GeV fm}, \quad \hbar \simeq 6.58212 \times 10^{-25} \text{ GeV s}. \quad (1.1.3)$$

Consequently,

$$1 \text{ GeV}^{-1} \simeq 0.1973 \text{ fm} \simeq 6.582 \times 10^{-25} \text{ s}. \quad (1.1.4)$$

1.1.2 Mass dimension

It is convenient to write $[X] = n$ when the quantity X has mass dimension n , meaning $X \sim (\text{mass})^n$. Since the phase e^{iS} must be dimensionless,

$$[S] = 0. \quad (1.1.5)$$

In d spacetime dimensions,

$$[d^d x] = -d, \quad [\partial_\mu] = 1, \quad [\mathcal{L}] = d, \quad (1.1.6)$$

because $S = \int d^d x \mathcal{L}$.

The kinetic terms then determine the canonical dimensions of fields. For a real scalar, a Dirac spinor, and a gauge field (all of which will be introduced subsequently),

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{scalar}} \supset \frac{1}{2}(\partial_\mu \phi)(\partial^\mu \phi), \quad [\phi] = \frac{d-2}{2}, \quad (1.1.7)$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{Dirac}} \supset \bar{\psi} i \gamma^\mu \partial_\mu \psi, \quad [\psi] = \frac{d-1}{2}, \quad (1.1.8)$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{gauge}} \supset -\frac{1}{4} F_{\mu\nu} F^{\mu\nu}, \quad [A_\mu] = \frac{d-2}{2}. \quad (1.1.9)$$

Here $F_{\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu A_\nu - \partial_\nu A_\mu$. In four dimensions this becomes

$$[\phi] = 1, \quad [\psi] = \frac{3}{2}, \quad [A_\mu] = 1. \quad (1.1.10)$$

If an interaction is written as $g_{\mathcal{O}} \mathcal{O}$, where $[\mathcal{O}] = \Delta_{\mathcal{O}}$, then

$$[g_{\mathcal{O}}] = d - \Delta_{\mathcal{O}}. \quad (1.1.11)$$

This elementary relation anticipates the classification of interactions in effective field theory:

Interaction in $d = 4$	Operator dimension	Coupling dimension
$\frac{\lambda}{4!} \phi^4$	4	$[\lambda] = 0$
$y \phi \bar{\psi} \psi$	4	$[y] = 0$
$\frac{g_6}{6!} \phi^6$	6	$[g_6] = -2$
$\frac{c}{\Lambda} \phi F_{\mu\nu} F^{\mu\nu}$	5	$[c/\Lambda] = -1$

Couplings of positive, zero, and negative mass dimension are called relevant, marginal, and irrelevant at the classical level, respectively. Quantum corrections refine this classification; see, for example, Refs. [2, 3].

Example: the dimension of a scalar coupling in general d

Consider $\mathcal{L}_{\text{int}} = -g_n \phi^n / n!$. Since $[\phi] = (d - 2)/2$,

$$[g_n] = d - \frac{n(d - 2)}{2}. \quad (1.1.12)$$

For $n = 4$, $[g_4] = 4 - d$. Thus ϕ^4 is classically marginal in four dimensions, relevant below four dimensions, and irrelevant above four dimensions.

1.2 Lorentz transformations and index notation

1.2.1 Events, intervals, and the metric

An event in Minkowski spacetime is represented by the contravariant vector

$$x^\mu = (x^0, x^1, x^2, x^3) = (t, x, y, z). \quad (1.2.1)$$

The Minkowski metric and its inverse are

$$\eta_{\mu\nu} = \eta^{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (1.2.2)$$

Indices are lowered and raised with the metric:

$$x_\mu = \eta_{\mu\nu} x^\nu = (t, -x, -y, -z), \quad x^\mu = \eta^{\mu\nu} x_\nu. \quad (1.2.3)$$

Thus an upstairs spatial component and its downstairs counterpart differ by a minus sign. The invariant interval is

$$x^2 \equiv x_\mu x^\mu = \eta_{\mu\nu} x^\mu x^\nu = t^2 - \mathbf{x}^2. \quad (1.2.4)$$

Intervals are timelike, null, or spacelike according as x^2 is positive, zero, or negative respectively.

1.2.2 Contravariant and covariant objects

A Lorentz transformation is a linear map

$$x'^\mu = \Lambda^\mu_\nu x^\nu \quad (1.2.5)$$

that preserves the metric:

$$\Lambda^\top \eta \Lambda = \eta, \quad \text{or in components} \quad \eta_{\rho\sigma} \Lambda^\rho_\mu \Lambda^\sigma_\nu = \eta_{\mu\nu}. \quad (1.2.6)$$

An object transforming as in [equation \(1.2.5\)](#) is a contravariant vector. A covector transforms with the inverse matrix:

$$a'_\mu = (\Lambda^{-1})^\nu_\mu a_\nu = \Lambda_\mu^\nu a_\nu. \quad (1.2.7)$$

More generally, every upper index receives one factor of Λ and every lower index one factor of Λ^{-1} .

For a boost of speed v along the x -direction,

$$\begin{pmatrix} t' \\ x' \\ y' \\ z' \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \gamma & -\gamma v & 0 & 0 \\ -\gamma v & \gamma & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} t \\ x \\ y \\ z \end{pmatrix}, \quad \gamma = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-v^2}}. \quad (1.2.8)$$

Direct multiplication verifies [equation \(1.2.6\)](#).

1.2.3 Derivatives and index placement

The spacetime derivative is naturally a covector. By the chain rule,

$$\partial'_\mu \equiv \frac{\partial}{\partial x'^\mu} = \frac{\partial x^\nu}{\partial x'^\mu} \frac{\partial}{\partial x^\nu} = (\Lambda^{-1})^\nu_\mu \partial_\nu. \quad (1.2.9)$$

With the mostly-minus metric,

$$\partial_\mu = (\partial_t, \nabla), \quad \partial^\mu = (\partial_t, -\nabla). \quad (1.2.10)$$

The d'Alembertian is the Lorentz-invariant differential operator

$$\square \equiv \partial_\mu \partial^\mu = \partial_t^2 - \nabla^2. \quad (1.2.11)$$

1.2.4 Lorentz-invariant contractions

Let a^μ and b^μ be Lorentz vectors. Their transformed inner product is

$$a' \cdot b' = \eta_{\mu\nu} a'^\mu b'^\nu \quad (1.2.12)$$

$$= \eta_{\mu\nu} \Lambda^\mu{}_\rho \Lambda^\nu{}_\sigma a^\rho b^\sigma \quad (1.2.13)$$

$$= \eta_{\rho\sigma} a^\rho b^\sigma = a \cdot b, \quad (1.2.14)$$

where the Lorentz condition [equation \(1.2.6\)](#) was used on the third line. In matrix notation, this is simply

$$a'^T \eta b' = a^T \Lambda^T \eta \Lambda b = a^T \eta b. \quad (1.2.15)$$

Important examples of Lorentz scalars and invariant expressions include

$$x^2 = t^2 - \mathbf{x}^2, \quad p^2 = E^2 - \mathbf{p}^2 = m^2, \quad (1.2.16)$$

$$p \cdot x = Et - \mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{x}, \quad \partial_\mu \phi \partial^\mu \phi = (\partial_t \phi)^2 - (\nabla \phi)^2, \quad (1.2.17)$$

$$F_{\mu\nu} F^{\mu\nu} = 2(\mathbf{B}^2 - \mathbf{E}^2), \quad \bar{\psi} \psi = \text{Lorentz scalar}. \quad (1.2.18)$$

For proper Lorentz transformations, $\det \Lambda = +1$, the integration measure d^4x is also invariant. Under the full Lorentz group one may more precisely write $d^4x' = |\det \Lambda| d^4x = d^4x$.

Not every object with no free index is an ordinary scalar. For example, $\epsilon_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} F^{\mu\nu} F^{\rho\sigma}$ is a *pseudoscalar*: it changes sign under improper Lorentz transformations such as parity. This distinction becomes important when discrete symmetries are discussed.

1.3 Relativistic single-particle quantum mechanics and its limitations

In nonrelativistic quantum mechanics, the Hamiltonian of a free particle is $H = \mathbf{p}^2 / (2m)$. A tempting relativistic replacement is

$$H = \sqrt{\mathbf{p}^2 + m^2}, \quad (1.3.1)$$

keeping only the positive-energy branch. This apparently reasonable theory contains a deep localization problem. The discussion below follows the standard motivation given in Refs. [\[1, 2, 3\]](#).

Suppose a particle is perfectly localized at the origin at $t = 0$. In the position basis, the amplitude to detect it at $\mathbf{x}$ after time t is formally

$$K(t, \mathbf{x}) = \langle \mathbf{x} | e^{-iHt} | \mathbf{0} \rangle = \int \frac{d^3p}{(2\pi)^3} \exp \left[i\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{x} - i\sqrt{\mathbf{p}^2 + m^2} t \right]. \quad (1.3.2)$$

If a strictly localized relativistic particle respected naive one-particle causality, this amplitude would vanish whenever $r \equiv |\mathbf{x}| > t$. It does not.

To see the origin of this result cleanly, introduce the positive-frequency two-point function

$$\Delta^+(x) = \int \frac{d^3p}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{2E_p} e^{-iE_p t + i\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{x}}, \quad E_p = \sqrt{\mathbf{p}^2 + m^2}. \quad (1.3.3)$$

The kernel in [equation \(1.3.2\)](#) satisfies

$$K(t, x) = 2i \partial_t \Delta^+(x). \quad (1.3.4)$$

For a spacelike separation, define

$$\rho \equiv \sqrt{r^2 - t^2} > 0. \quad (1.3.5)$$

The momentum integral can be evaluated in terms of a modified Bessel function:

$$\Delta^+(x) = \frac{m}{4\pi^2 \rho} K_1(m\rho), \quad x^2 < 0. \quad (1.3.6)$$

Since $K_1(z)$ is nonzero for positive z , both $\Delta^+(x)$ and, for generic t , the transition kernel have an exponentially small but nonzero spacelike tail. At $m\rho \gg 1$,

$$\Delta^+(x) \sim \frac{\sqrt{m}}{4\sqrt{2} \pi^{3/2} \rho^{3/2}} e^{-m\rho}. \quad (1.3.7)$$

The characteristic distance is the Compton wavelength m^{-1} . Attempting to localize a particle on shorter scales requires momenta large enough to make particle production energetically possible, so a fixed-particle-number description has left its domain of validity.

1.4 Classical fields and the action principle

1.4.1 From coordinates to fields

In point-particle mechanics, the dynamical variables are a finite collection of generalized coordinates $q_a(t)$. In field theory, the dynamical variables are fields $\phi_a(x)$, one value at every spacetime point. The discrete label a may distinguish species or internal components; it is not a spacetime index unless explicitly stated.

For a local first-derivative theory, the Lagrangian density is

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}(\phi_a, \partial_\mu \phi_a; x), \quad (1.4.1)$$

and the action is

$$S[\phi] = \int_{\Omega} d^d x \mathcal{L}. \quad (1.4.2)$$

The Lagrangian density may change by a total derivative without changing the bulk equations of motion:

$$\mathcal{L} \longrightarrow \mathcal{L} + \partial_\mu K^\mu. \quad (1.4.3)$$

The action then changes only by a boundary term. Boundary terms are not always physically irrelevant—they matter for boundaries, conserved charges, and gravity—but they do not modify the local Euler–Lagrange equations when the variations obey the assumed boundary conditions.

1.4.2 Deriving the field Euler–Lagrange equations

Consider an arbitrary infinitesimal variation

$$\phi_a(x) \longrightarrow \phi_a(x) + \epsilon \delta \phi_a(x), \quad (1.4.4)$$

with $\delta\phi_a = 0$ on the boundary $\partial\Omega$. To first order,

$$\delta S = \int_{\Omega} d^d x \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi_a} \delta\phi_a + \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu} \phi_a)} \partial_{\mu} (\delta\phi_a) \right] \quad (1.4.5)$$

$$= \int_{\Omega} d^d x \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi_a} - \partial_{\mu} \left(\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu} \phi_a)} \right) \right] \delta\phi_a + \int_{\partial\Omega} d\Sigma_{\mu} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu} \phi_a)} \delta\phi_a. \quad (1.4.6)$$

The boundary term vanishes by assumption. Since the remaining $\delta\phi_a(x)$ are arbitrary, stationarity $\delta S = 0$ implies

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi_a} - \partial_{\mu} \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu} \phi_a)} \right] = 0. \quad (1.4.7)$$

This is the field-theory Euler–Lagrange equation. It is the direct analogue of its point-particle counterpart,

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial q_a} - \frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{\partial L}{\partial \dot{q}_a} \right) = 0. \quad (1.4.8)$$

1.4.3 Higher-derivative Lagrangians

A local Lagrangian density may, in principle, depend on derivatives of arbitrarily high order. If

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}(\phi_a, \partial_{\mu} \phi_a, \partial_{\mu} \partial_{\nu} \phi_a), \quad (1.4.9)$$

two integrations by parts give

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi_a} - \partial_{\mu} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu} \phi_a)} + \partial_{\mu} \partial_{\nu} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu} \partial_{\nu} \phi_a)} = 0. \quad (1.4.10)$$

The appropriate boundary conditions now fix both $\delta\phi_a$ and its first normal derivative. For derivatives through order N , the compact result is

$$\sum_{n=0}^N (-1)^n \partial_{\mu_1} \cdots \partial_{\mu_n} \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_{\mu_1} \cdots \partial_{\mu_n} \phi_a)} \right] = 0, \quad (1.4.11)$$

where the $n = 0$ term means $\partial \mathcal{L} / \partial \phi_a$.

The predominance of first-derivative Lagrangians in elementary field theory has several reasons:

- A nondegenerate Lagrangian with higher time derivatives generally yields higher-order equations of motion, requires extra initial data, and suffers from the Ostrogradsky instability: its Hamiltonian is unbounded below.
- Additional derivatives increase operator dimension, so such terms are often suppressed by powers of a high scale in an effective field theory.
- First-derivative actions already generate second-order equations, which supply the familiar relativistic wave propagation problem.

These statements have important qualifications. Total derivatives do not add dynamics; constrained or degenerate higher-derivative theories can evade the Ostrogradsky conclusion; and higher-derivative operators are routinely used perturbatively in effective field theory.

1.5 Examples of Euler–Lagrange equations

1.5.1 A real scalar field

Consider

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{2} \partial_\mu \phi \partial^\mu \phi - V(\phi). \quad (1.5.1)$$

The two Euler–Lagrange derivatives are

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi} = -V'(\phi), \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu \phi)} = \partial^\mu \phi. \quad (1.5.2)$$

Therefore,

$$\square \phi + V'(\phi) = 0. \quad (1.5.3)$$

For $V(\phi) = m^2 \phi^2 / 2$, this reduces to the Klein–Gordon equation

$$(\square + m^2) \phi = 0. \quad (1.5.4)$$

A plane wave $\phi \sim e^{-ip \cdot x}$ satisfies this equation only if

$$p^2 = m^2, \quad \text{i.e.} \quad E^2 = \mathbf{p}^2 + m^2. \quad (1.5.5)$$

Thus Lorentz invariance of the action directly produces the relativistic dispersion relation.

For the interacting potential

$$V(\phi) = \frac{1}{2} m^2 \phi^2 + \frac{\lambda}{4!} \phi^4, \quad (1.5.6)$$

the equation becomes

$$(\square + m^2) \phi + \frac{\lambda}{3!} \phi^3 = 0. \quad (1.5.7)$$

1.5.2 A complex scalar field

Let

$$\mathcal{L} = \partial_\mu \phi^* \partial^\mu \phi - m^2 \phi^* \phi - \frac{\lambda}{2} (\phi^* \phi)^2. \quad (1.5.8)$$

Although ϕ^* is the complex conjugate of ϕ , they are treated as independent variables during variation (equivalently, a complex scalar may be regarded as two real scalar fields). Varying with respect to ϕ^* ,

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi^*} = -m^2 \phi - \lambda (\phi^* \phi) \phi, \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu \phi^*)} = \partial^\mu \phi, \quad (1.5.9)$$

and hence

$$(\square + m^2) \phi + \lambda (\phi^* \phi) \phi = 0. \quad (1.5.10)$$

Varying with respect to ϕ gives the complex-conjugate equation. The Lagrangian is invariant under the global transformation $\phi \rightarrow e^{i\alpha} \phi$, which will furnish a conserved current and a conserved charge through Noether's theorem.

1.5.3 The electromagnetic field

The gauge potential A_μ defines the antisymmetric field strength

$$F_{\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu A_\nu - \partial_\nu A_\mu. \quad (1.5.11)$$

In the presence of an external current j^μ , take

$$\mathcal{L} = -\frac{1}{4}F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu} - j^\mu A_\mu. \quad (1.5.12)$$

The Lagrangian depends on A_ν through the source term and on its derivative through $F_{\mu\nu}$:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial A_\nu} = -j^\nu, \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)} = -F^{\mu\nu}. \quad (1.5.13)$$

The Euler–Lagrange equation is therefore

$$\partial_\mu F^{\mu\nu} = j^\nu, \quad (1.5.14)$$

which contains Gauss’s law and the Ampère–Maxwell law. The remaining two Maxwell equations follow identically from the definition of $F_{\mu\nu}$:

$$\partial_\lambda F_{\mu\nu} + \partial_\mu F_{\nu\lambda} + \partial_\nu F_{\lambda\mu} = 0. \quad (1.5.15)$$

Taking ∂_ν of [equation \(1.5.14\)](#) gives

$$\partial_\nu j^\nu = \partial_\nu \partial_\mu F^{\mu\nu} = 0, \quad (1.5.16)$$

because the derivatives are symmetric in μ, ν while $F^{\mu\nu}$ is antisymmetric. Current conservation is thus required for consistency.

The action is unchanged under

$$A_\mu \longrightarrow A_\mu + \partial_\mu \alpha, \quad (1.5.17)$$

provided the source is conserved (up to a boundary term). This gauge redundancy will later be central to quantizing the electromagnetic field.

1.6 Continuous symmetries and Noether’s theorem

Noether’s theorem establishes the precise relation between continuous symmetries of the action and conservation laws. Consider a collection of fields $\phi_a(x)$ with

$$S[\phi] = \int d^d x \mathcal{L}(\phi_a, \partial_\mu \phi_a; x). \quad (1.6.1)$$

For an infinitesimal continuous transformation with constant parameter ϵ , write

$$x^\mu \longrightarrow x'^\mu = x^\mu + \epsilon \Delta x^\mu, \quad \phi_a(x) \longrightarrow \phi'_a(x') = \phi_a(x) + \epsilon \Delta \phi_a(x). \quad (1.6.2)$$

It is useful to distinguish the total field variation $\Delta \phi_a$ from the variation at fixed spacetime point,

$$\delta_0 \phi_a \equiv \phi'_a(x) - \phi_a(x) = \Delta \phi_a - \Delta x^\nu \partial_\nu \phi_a. \quad (1.6.3)$$

Define the canonical momentum density

$$\pi_a^\mu \equiv \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu \phi_a)}. \quad (1.6.4)$$

A direct variation of the Lagrangian gives the identity

$$\delta \mathcal{L} = \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi_a} - \partial_\mu \pi_a^\mu \right] \delta_0 \phi_a + \partial_\mu (\pi_a^\mu \delta_0 \phi_a) + \partial_\mu (\mathcal{L} \Delta x^\mu). \quad (1.6.5)$$

Suppose the transformation changes the Lagrangian by at most a total derivative,

$$\delta \mathcal{L} = \partial_\mu K^\mu. \quad (1.6.6)$$

Then the Noether current may be written as

$$j^\mu = \pi_a^\mu \delta_0 \phi_a + \mathcal{L} \Delta x^\mu - K^\mu. \quad (1.6.7)$$

1.6.1 Weak and strong forms

The relation following from [equations \(1.6.5\) and \(1.6.6\)](#) is

$$\partial_\mu j^\mu = - \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \phi_a} - \partial_\mu \left(\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu \phi_a)} \right) \right] \delta_0 \phi_a. \quad (1.6.8)$$

This identity holds without imposing the equations of motion and is often referred to as the *strong* form of Noether's theorem. On shell, the Euler–Lagrange equations set the bracket to zero and one obtains

$$\boxed{\partial_\mu j^\mu = 0}, \quad (1.6.9)$$

which is the usual *weak* or on-shell conservation law.

The associated charge is

$$Q = \int d^{d-1}x j^0. \quad (1.6.10)$$

Using the continuity equation,

$$\frac{dQ}{dt} = - \int d^{d-1}x \nabla \cdot \mathbf{j} = - \left(\oint_{S_\infty} d\mathbf{S} \cdot \mathbf{j} \right) \rightarrow 0. \quad (1.6.11)$$

Hence Q is conserved provided the flux through spatial infinity vanishes.

1.6.2 Internal symmetries

For an internal transformation the coordinates are unchanged, $\Delta x^\mu = 0$. If the Lagrangian is exactly invariant, $K^\mu = 0$, the current reduces to

$$j^\mu = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu \phi_a)} \delta \phi_a. \quad (1.6.12)$$

Constant shift symmetry. Consider the free massless scalar field

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{2} \partial_\mu \phi \partial^\mu \phi. \quad (1.6.13)$$

It is invariant under

$$\phi(x) \longrightarrow \phi(x) + \epsilon, \quad \delta\phi = 1. \quad (1.6.14)$$

The Noether current is therefore

$$j^\mu = \partial^\mu \phi, \quad (1.6.15)$$

with

$$\partial_\mu j^\mu = \square\phi = 0 \quad (1.6.16)$$

on shell. A mass term or a nonconstant potential breaks this shift symmetry explicitly.

Global phase symmetry. For the complex (charged) scalar theory in [equation \(1.5.8\)](#), the infinitesimal form of

$$\phi \longrightarrow e^{i\alpha} \phi, \quad \phi^* \longrightarrow e^{-i\alpha} \phi^* \quad (1.6.17)$$

is

$$\delta\phi = i\phi, \quad \delta\phi^* = -i\phi^*. \quad (1.6.18)$$

Applying [equation \(1.6.12\)](#) gives

$$j^\mu = i(\phi \partial^\mu \phi^* - \phi^* \partial^\mu \phi). \quad (1.6.19)$$

Equivalently, one may reverse the overall sign by reversing the convention for the infinitesimal parameter. The conserved charge

$$Q = \int d^3x j^0 \quad (1.6.20)$$

is the Noether charge associated with the global $U(1)$ symmetry.

1.6.3 Spacetime translations and the energy momentum tensor

Spacetime transformations act both on the coordinates and on the fields. For translations,

$$x^\mu \longrightarrow x'^\mu = x^\mu + \epsilon^\mu, \quad (1.6.21)$$

with a scalar field transforming according to

$$\phi'(x') = \phi(x). \quad (1.6.22)$$

At fixed x this gives

$$\delta_0\phi = -\epsilon^\nu \partial_\nu \phi. \quad (1.6.23)$$

The corresponding Noether current can be written

$$j^\mu = -\epsilon_\nu T^{\mu\nu}, \quad (1.6.24)$$

where

$$T^\mu{}_\nu = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu \phi_a)} \partial_\nu \phi_a - \delta^\mu{}_\nu \mathcal{L} \quad (1.6.25)$$

is the canonical energy–momentum tensor. Translation invariance implies

$$\partial_\mu T^\mu{}_\nu = 0. \quad (1.6.26)$$

The four conserved charges are

$$P_\nu = \int d^3x T^0{}_\nu. \quad (1.6.27)$$

Thus time-translation invariance gives conservation of energy,

$$H = P^0 = \int d^3x T^{00}, \quad (1.6.28)$$

and the three independent spatial translations give conservation of the three components of momentum,

$$P^i = \int d^3x T^{0i}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3. \quad (1.6.29)$$

These constitute the four conserved charges associated with spacetime translations.

References

- [1] M. E. Peskin and D. V. Schroeder, *An Introduction to Quantum Field Theory* (Addison–Wesley, Reading, Massachusetts, 1995).
- [2] M. Srednicki, *Quantum Field Theory* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 2007).
- [3] M. D. Schwartz, *Quantum Field Theory and the Standard Model* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 2014).
- [4] D. Tong, *Lectures on Quantum Field Theory*, University of Cambridge Part III Mathematical Tripos lecture notes, <https://www.damtp.cam.ac.uk/user/tong/qft.html>.
- [5] T. J. Osborne, *Lectures on Quantum Field Theory*, Leibniz University Hannover. Lecture notes transcribed by A. V. St. John, <https://github.com/avstjohn/qft>.
- [6] P. Ramond, *Field Theory: A Modern Primer*, 2nd ed. (Addison–Wesley, Redwood City, California, 1989).
- [7] T.P. Cheng and L.F. Li, *Gauge Theory of Elementary Particle Physics* (Clarendon Press, Oxford, 1984).
- [8] S. Weinberg, *The Quantum Theory of Fields, Vol. I: Foundations* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1995).